Pip

Concept

Pip is a desktop companion that lives on top of whatever software the person is already using, like spreadsheets, email or chat. Instead of being another app to open, it shows up as small overlays at the edges of the screen. It gives just enough help to get the next step done, then gets out of the way.

The goal is to support executive function during the first job, which means planning, starting tasks and understanding unclear instructions, without taking over the screen.

How it works

Pip has four sizes, and it only grows when the person needs more.

- **Docked** is a small Pip at the edge of the screen. A ring around it shows progress on the current task.
- **Peek** is a one-line pill that says what comes next, for example "Next, paste totals into column C."
- **Task card** is a compact card with one instruction at a time. It explains exactly where to click and which keys to press. A highlight also appears inside the real app, so the person sees the exact spot.
- **Steps window** appears when the person highlights confusing text, like a vague email from their manager. It turns the text into a short task with three plain steps and a deadline. An optional "How did Pip read this?" link explains phrases like "circle back" for people who want to learn the unwritten rules.

Support without pressure

- An "I'm stuck" button asks what's in the way and offers to point to the spot again, split the step, or explain it differently.
- If a step is taking a long time, Pip gently offers to make it smaller or suggests a short break. It never scolds.
- Urgency is shown with a small icon and plain words, never with red or yellow alerts.

Privacy and control

A simple privacy panel lets the person decide when Pip can look at the screen (never, only when asked, or during a task) and which apps it can see. Screenshots are deleted after reading. Sharing anything with a job coach is off by default and always needs the person's approval. A Pause all button stops everything at once.

The character

Pip is a single rounded shape whose eyes do all the expressing. It has 12 moods, including calm, thinking, happy, gentle, showing, quiet, hello, celebrate, sleepy, reading, listening and thanks.

It blinks every few seconds, bobs gently, and peeks over the top edge of cards. All motion turns off if the person has reduced motion enabled in their system settings.

The character makes the tool feel friendly and human rather than clinical, which matters for people who may already feel anxious in a new job.

Color palette, "Harbor"

Color	Hex	Role
Deep blue	#3368A0	Main buttons, highlights, progress and links
Sky blue	#66A3BF	Pip only, so the character is always recognizable
Soft mint	#C8DFDB	Gentle fills like step numbers
Warm cream	#F8F6F1	Background of every overlay card, lightened slightly from the original #F2EFE7

Supporting tones are navy text (#1E2A36), a softer body text (#3A4652), muted labels (#55626E) and a light border (#DCD7CB). The base palette comes from Color Hunt.

Why this palette

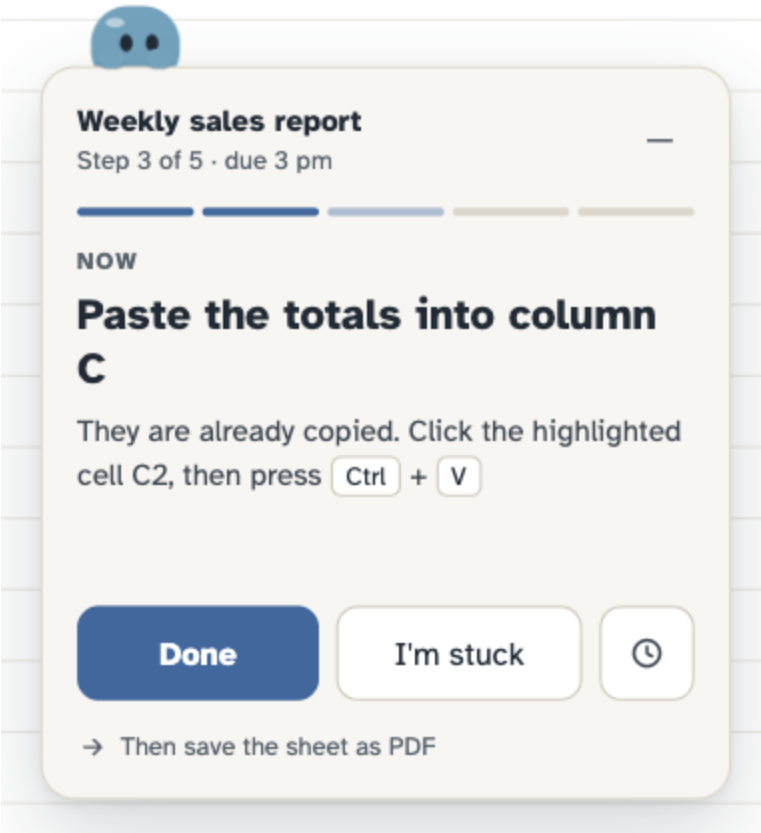
- **Calm, not loud.** Cool blues and soft mint keep visual stimulation low, which helps people with sensory sensitivities. The palette has no red or yellow, so nothing feels like an alarm.
- **Readable.** Research on reading shows dark text on a light background is easier to read, especially at small sizes like overlay text (Piepenbrock et al.). The British Dyslexia Association recommends dark (not black) text on an off-white (not pure white) background to reduce glare. That's why the cards use warm cream and navy instead of white and black.
- **Stands out from other apps.** The warm cream card, soft shadow and thin border keep Pip clearly separate from white work apps like Excel or Outlook, without being harsh.
- **Accessible.** All text meets WCAG contrast standards. Colors that need to be told apart also differ in lightness, not just hue.

Typography

Atkinson Hyperlegible, a typeface designed to make letters easy to tell apart, which helps with dyslexia and low vision.

Light and dark

Light mode is the default. A dark version is planned because some neurodivergent users find dark screens less overstimulating, and Pip will follow the computer's light or dark setting. A low-stimulation theme based on the softer "Mist" palette could be offered as an option.



Pip

One shape, the eyes do the talking. Blinks every few seconds, bobs gently, stays still with reduced motion on.



Harbor, current

#3368A0 #66A3BF #C8DFDB #F2EFE7

Weekly sales report
Step 3 of 5

NOW

Paste the totals into column C

Click cell C2, then press Ctrl + V

Done | I'm stuck

Due 3 pm

Got it. Here's what Laura needs

Send Laura an update on the vendor list

By Thursday, 10 am

1. Open the vendor list
2. Check if anything is missing
3. Reply to Laura with the file

Start step 1 | Save for later

Step 3 done



https://canva.link/dv2bgf5xclz1mch